

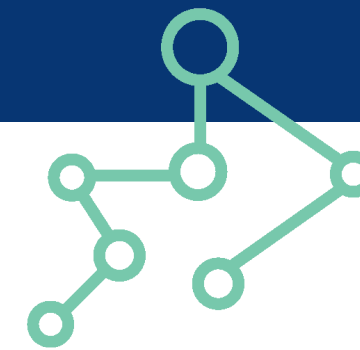
UK Council for
Graduate Education

Annual Report 2023-24

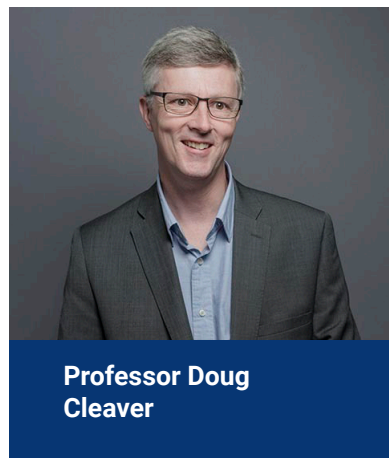
We enable collective leadership for the postgraduate sector.



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Introduction



Professor Doug Cleaver



Professor Janet de Wilde



Dr Owen Gower

Dear colleagues,

We would like to open this annual report by thanking our trustees, whose enthusiasm, professionalism and hard work has provided a solid foundation on which we have grown our activities. We also wish to thank you – our members – for your support for our activities: by participating in events, by taking part in our professional networks, by conducting research, and by advising us on what you think the priorities for the postgraduate sector should be. To be as effective as we are, we rely on voluntary contributions such as these and are grateful for them.

As you know, the Council plays a key role in supporting the development of the postgraduate sector with a wide range of activities at both the national and international level. The last 12 months have been a particularly exciting time for us – we have held a mixture of debates and workshops, including our first EDI Conference (p. 12), and we have also fostered some important partnerships, one of which is with the Next Generation Research SuperVision Project (RSVP) (p. 5).

Over the last year we have made some significant operational changes at UKCGE which are already having a positive impact on our work. In March 2023 the annual general meeting agreed to raise subscription rates. This has enabled us to make online events free of charge to members, and to respond quickly to your requests for guidance. This has resulted in a much broader range of discussions and an increased number of event attendances.

This annual report highlights some of what we've achieved together over the last year – thank you again for your support.

Professor Doug Cleaver, Chair UKCGE

Professor Janet de Wilde, Vice-Chair UKCGE

Dr Owen Gower, Director UKCGE

News from our Networks



Left: Dr Nigel Eady and Professor Bonnie Steves, Co-Chairs of the DDD Network.
Right: Susanna Broom and Kerri Gardiner, Co-Chairs of the PEP Network.

Two of our networks changed their names this year; we welcomed one new Co-Chair and said a fond farewell to another as she embarked on retirement.

DDD Network

At the end of February 2024, the Doctoral Deans & Directors (DDD)Network (formerly Deans & Directors of Graduate Schools) met for a highly successful residential workshop held across two days at the Pullman Hotel in Liverpool.

Co-Chair Dr Nigel Eady (King's College London) said: "The residential provides space to discuss challenges and opportunities with peers who understand the pressures and context we work in. The open and honest exchanges are a great

motivator and encouragement." The Equity in Doctoral Education through Partnership and Innovation (EDEPI) Project was one of the focuses for discussion (see p. 4).

Before the event started, Professor Bonnie Steves revealed she is stepping down as Co-Chair, following her retirement as Director of the Graduate School at Glasgow Caledonian University – a post she held for 17 years. She added that the DDD workshop was a great way to spend the first day of her retirement!

PEP Network

The Graduate Education Managers' (GEM) Network also changed its name in 2023 to become the Postgraduate Education Practitioners' (PEP) Network. With Mary-Beth

Kneafsey's tenure as Co-Chair ending in 2023, Susanna Broom (Head of the Researcher School at the University of Sussex) was elected in her place, taking up her post alongside fellow Co-Chair Kerri Gardiner (Head of the Postgraduate Research Office, University of Cambridge).

Explaining the reason for the name change during their first workshop together, Susanna and Kerri said: "We thought it was an opportunity for this network to be an inclusive, safe space and not necessarily for those at a managerial level. Quite often the PGR experience is the forgotten experience – but in fact we are all experts in this space. The network is an opportunity to champion this expertise within the wider UKCGE community and, in time, champion it in our institutions."





2023-24 Highlights

It's been an exceptionally busy year in which we've enjoyed seeing friends old and new. We've also been involved in some vital projects which tackle inequalities within our sector.

1.

The Sir Bob Burgess Memorial Lecture, held annually in memory of UKCGE's Founding Chair, took place at London's British Academy on November 9th 2023. We were delighted to welcome Professor Barbara Dooley, Deputy President of University College, Dublin, who gave a fascinating presentation entitled The Postgraduate Research Landscape in Europe. Her lecture considered, at a high level, what trends are emerging and where the drivers are behind those trends, while referencing key stakeholders such as the European University Association (EUA).

Professor Dooley reflected that the recent pandemic has brought into sharp focus the importance of digitalisation and observed that subjects high on the European agenda include open science, ethics and integrity, the reform of academic careers, the promotion of interdisciplinarity and the strengthening of civic engagement.

2.

This year we partnered with The EDEPI Project, based at Nottingham Trent University, to conduct a thorough investigation into 'as is' admissions practices at UK higher education institutions.

Through rigorous analysis, the Project uncovered ten barriers in the PGR admissions process for individuals who were from racially-minoritised groups. One key barrier was the over-reliance on applicants' Master's degrees and degree-awarding institution as the main assessment criteria, a practice which tends to perpetuate systemic inequalities.

The Project has resulted in a Competency-Based Admissions Framework which is now being piloted at three UK universities.

3.

On July 3rd and 4th 2023, we welcomed 120 delegates to our Annual Conference: Ensuring Quality and Delivering Growth in Postgraduate Education. The event – hosted by UKCGE, trustee Dr Gale Macleod and the University of Edinburgh – considered how the rapid growth in the postgraduate sector should be managed while still maintaining quality.

The Conference kicked off with a welcome and introduction from Professor Colm Harmon, Vice-Principal Students at the University of Edinburgh, and followed with a packed schedule of keynotes and smaller talks. Two days of lively debate and analysis followed, at the end of which the UKCGE Executive Committee provided its reflections on the event. During this session our postgraduate panel – where PhD candidates spoke frankly about their experiences – was repeatedly mentioned as a high point.

4.

Next Generation Research SuperVision Project (RSVP)

In July 2023, we were delighted to announce that UKCGE is collaborating on a £4.6million project, led by the University of York, that seeks to transform the culture and practice of research supervision across the UK. The £4.6million Next Generation Research SuperVision Project (RSVP) commenced in October 2023 and will run for four years until Autumn 2027. RSVP is funded by Research England and supported by all seven UKRI Research Councils and the Wellcome Trust.

Along with UKCGE, the project will be undertaken by a consortium of five UK Higher Education Institutions (York, Coventry, King's College London, Nottingham and Sheffield

Hallam) and is led by Dr Karen Clegg (University of York) and Professor Doug Cleaver (Sheffield Hallam University). A further 15+ universities (including international partners) will be recruited to pilot and evaluate professional development interventions, while major industries (including GSK, Unilever, the BBC and the Royal Shakespeare Company) will also contribute expertise.

On February 27th 2024, UKCGE hosted an online launch event for the project with an introduction from Steven Hill (Director of Research at Research England) and contributions from a range of stakeholders, including Dr Heather Sears (Coventry University), Dr Alex Pavey

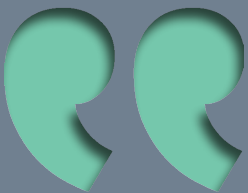
(King's College London) and Professor Richard Graham (University of Nottingham). Dr Clegg, Co-Director, outlined the project's scope. "We want to celebrate and support the work that doctoral supervisors do and we also want to bring on the next generation," she said.

Over 200 people attended to hear about the project's aims and to ask questions. Outputs will include a benchmarking of CPD for research supervision, a blueprint for team supervision, institutional guidelines and a set of world-leading professional development resources especially tailored for supervisors.

More details at www.rsvp.ac.uk.

Our Impact

Established in 1994, the UK Council for Graduate Education is the national representative body for postgraduate education and research. We are the third-largest representative body of its kind in the world, representing 92 per cent of all UK postgraduate research provision and 85 per cent of all UK postgraduate taught provision. We have an impact via sector events and publications, and we support academic professionals via our Networks. With the help of our Trustees, we also seek to influence Higher Education policy.



“An excellent event, that provided great opportunity to discuss, share and learn from colleagues across the sector.”
- Supporting the Growth of the Professional Doctorate.

“Outstanding event with high calibre excellent speakers. I would highly recommend all UKCGE events, and have now made sure to sign up for future events.” - Routes Out of PGR.

115

Number of UKCGE citations on Google Scholar since 2023.

730

Numbers of new followers on our Linkedin company page since April 2023.

59

Number of institutions which have participated in our Research Supervision Recognition Programme since its inception.

2,630

Number of attendees at our events for the period April 2023-March 2024.

185

Number of institutions participating in our events for the period April 2023-March 2024.

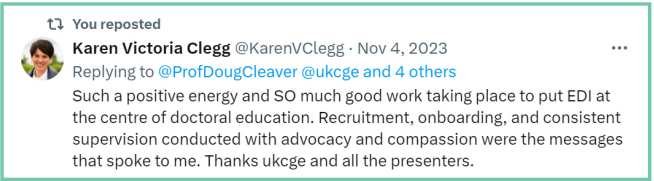
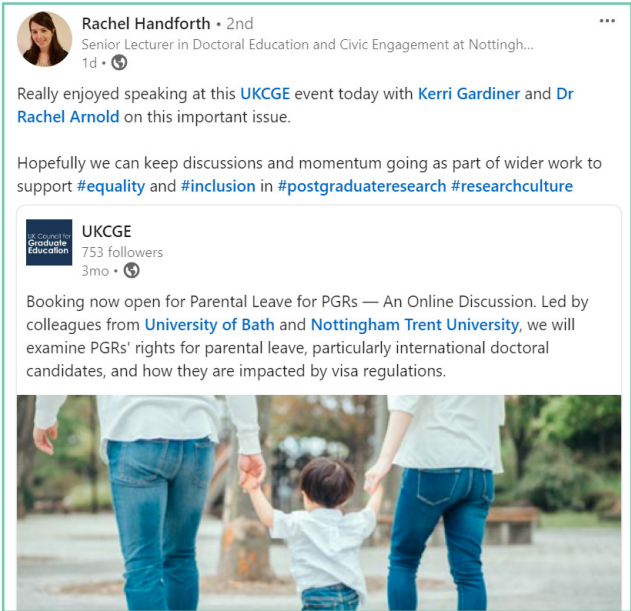
95%

Percentage of participants who rated our events as either “good” or “excellent” for the period April 2023-March 2024.



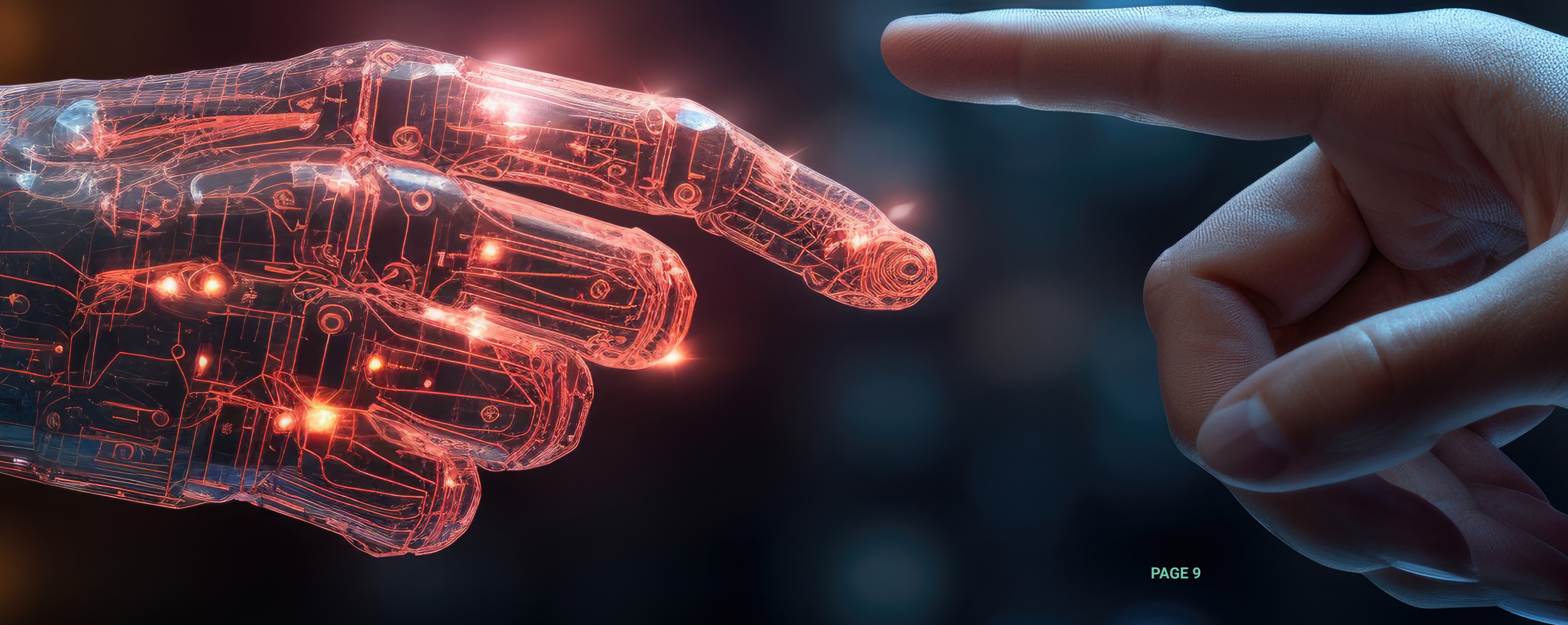
Professor Julie Sheldon, UKCGE Trustee:

In the last year the UKCGE has continued to play a crucial role in promoting continuous improvements in graduate education across institutions, through conversation and collaboration. The reach of the Council may be traced in a number of training, reports and publications, with an increase in citations reported on google scholar. The impact of the Good Supervisor Framework continues to be significant and accounts for 70% of citation on Google Scholar. The UKCGE continues to foster collaboration among universities to ensure the publication of high-quality reports and papers.



A.I. and Postgraduate Education

In April, we ran an online session which examined the impact on postgraduate education of ChatGPT, and other developments in Artificial Intelligence. A panel comprising Jorge Freire, Professor Philippe De Wilde, Dr Elena Forasacco and Sarah Hussain discussed how technologies like ChatGPT might enhance as well as challenge postgraduate work. The following are edited versions of the speakers' talk summaries.



Professor Philippe De Wilde (Professor of Artificial Intelligence, University of Kent) on 'Large language models, new tools for graduate education'.

We're seeing an explosion of interest in ChatGPT and similar software. After years of being (rightly) constrained by anti-plagiarism rules, here is a tool that will help our students with the pain and frustration of writing.

ChatGPT is a large language model (LLM), a huge piece of software trained on a large corpus of text. There are three main players in LLMs. Google has produced BERT, LaMDA and Bard. OpenAI, in partnership with Microsoft, has produced GPT 2, 3, and 4, ChatGPT, Bing Chat and DALL E (for images). The third focus of activity is in China, where LLMs such as Wu Dao and Ernie Bot are developed by Baidu and the Beijing Academy of Artificial Intelligence amongst others. Chinese LLMs form part of an increasingly sophisticated software environment helping Chinese-speaking students at English-medium universities.

LLMs are being steadily improved and integrated with search engines that cover a larger field of data. They offer PhD students scope for help with literature review, style improvement and finding computer code. They can also give advice on how to deal with PhD supervisors, family, even an empty fridge! And all this without plagiarism. I'm sold.

Dr Elena Forasacco (Senior Teaching Fellow, Imperial College London) on 'Generative AI, ChatGPT, and the Impact on Postgraduate Work'.

ChatGPT is taking an important place within the HE educational system, whether we like it or not. Banning the use of ChatGPT might be not the right solution since we cannot stop students from using it.

A possible suggestion is to shift the focus of assessments from the product to the process applied to obtain the product. Currently, our assessments and marking indicate the quality of assignments (e.g. essays); however, those assignments do not verify the students' learning. The use of ChatGPT will further emphasise this paradox. As already suggested by some HE educators, soon we might allow the use of ChatGPT for assignments; in that case, the suggestion is to evaluate the "question" asked to ChatGPT and not its final product, we will assess the process applied by students.

As Aristotle said "man is a rationale animal": if we remember this, apply our rationality and support students with the technology, ChatGPT will become a useful tool for us and our students.

Jorge Freire (Senior Learning Designer, Universidade Católica Portuguesa) on 'The Online postgraduate learner: digital learning, generative AI and disruption'.

The past three years have presented a series of challenges to Higher Education, of which generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) is the latest one. Why did generative AI impact HE so strongly? There might be three main causes for this impact: a lack of innovation and quality in assessment design; a refusal to improve asynchronous learning and assessment practice; slowness in adapting curriculum writing, teaching and assessment practice to current student living contexts.

The growth in distance postgraduate taught programmes allied to the continuous integration of generative AI into more software, mean that banning access to the technology is not an option. The social and market needs to develop the digital capabilities of our postgraduate students also demand a forward-looking approach.

Addressing generative AI's negative impact in assessment production is difficult because it affects parts of learning covered by shared remits in HE: information literacy, academic integrity, digital learning, digital capabilities, teaching and assessment practice. Only through the joining of skills of professional services and academic colleagues can we be agile enough to manage it.



Annual
Conference
2023

Recognising Associate Supervision

Dr Kay Guccione (University of Glasgow)

Following a successful pilot phase, the UKCGE launched the 'Recognised Associate Supervisor Award' in July 2023. This is a new part of the Research Supervision Recognition Programme, and the award, alongside the full 'Recognised Supervisor Award' provides a route to recognition for the many thousands of 'associate-level' supervisors – those early in their supervisory careers and those with informal supervisory roles – who are skilfully and diligently working to support PGRs across many of our higher education institutions.

At the annual conference in Edinburgh, I gave a keynote presentation underscoring the rationale for formalising of the concept of associate supervision, sometimes dismissed as 'just all part of the work' of, for example, postdoctoral research staff, technicians, PGR administrators or graduate school managers. I discussed the origins of the idea to recognise associate supervision, drawing from data collected as part of a Thesis Mentoring programme and showing how the skills and practices of supervision are developed through formal opportunities to engage in problem-solving with PGRs, such as through mentoring, careers discussions, and offering day-to-

day guidance and support.

Having this new award means that UKCGE can support recognition of the PGR enhancement work of a broader range of staff, and it supports the development of a whole-culture approach to PGR support. Additionally, it supports the idea that supervisory skills can be learned well before engaging in an 'official' supervision role. We very much hope that the Associate Award will recognise quickly growing numbers of colleagues over the next few years.

For more details please visit supervision.ukcge.ac.uk.



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Towards A More Equitable Sector

Our very first conference on Equity, Diversity and Inclusion in Postgraduate Research – held at Sheffield’s Crowne Plaza on the 2nd and 3rd of November 2023 – opened with a busy programme of talks and breakout sessions, all focussing on race and ethnicity in postgraduate research.

The morning keynote was presented by Professor Jason Arday (University of Cambridge) who observed that, in his experience, Black or ethnic minority researchers had always made a conscious decision to enter academia. He spoke about how he wanted to create a blueprint to help more people into scholarly careers and said that studying race is painful at times, because you’re listening to stories about people being denied. However, he added, this difficulty is necessary because it pushes people to change the situation. His talk received a standing ovation from the audience.

To close off the morning sessions, delegates were given an insight into the student experience with a PGR panel. Speaking were Princess Banda (University of Oxford), Anita Chonzi (Sheffield Hallam University) and Garth Dallas (Liverpool John Moores University). The latter talked about how, after challenging his university over how it interacted with local communities, it

came up with a positive action programme to get people from diverse backgrounds into PhD study. “You shouldn’t just aspire to climb the ladder – you should aspire to BE the ladder,” he observed.

Day 1 closed with another inspiring keynote (Call and Response: Inclusive Approaches to Supervision), this time from Dr Christine Edwards-Leis (St Mary’s University) and Dr Julie Spencer (ArtsEd). It used the call-and-response format in African traditional music to explore the ways in which Black or ethnic minority students might be hampered by the white-dominated ideology of the academy. Unusually, the session involved a capella singing from both presenters.

Final Day

The second day opened with a funders’ panel, with representatives from both the Wellcome Trust and Cancer Research UK addressing the topic of funding for diverse groups. A

highlight of the morning was the pre-lunch keynote from Dr Maria Augusta Arruda (Director of the Brazilian Biosciences National Laboratory) who delivered her talk over Zoom. “People will always try to reclaim the power because that’s the way it is,” she observed.



“For all of you that feel defeated I just wanted to say: you’re doing the right thing.”

At the end of Day 2, three members of the organising committee – Dr Francis Awolowo (Sheffield Hallam University), Mandy Gill (University of Nottingham) and Professor Hala Mansour (Royal College of Arts and UKCGE Executive) – summed up the event. Dr Awolowo said: “I want to thank every one of you for making this conference a huge success. I remember when we had our first meeting, trying to come up with a theme for this conference, and we felt the need to magnify race and ethnicity – we need to start talking about it – and I’m really glad we’ve done that with your support.”

Mandy Gill remarked: “It’s been a pleasure to meet so many wonderful people at this conference. A highlight was Jason [Arday] – his comment about white academics being able to say ‘I stumbled into it’ really stuck with me – how a person of colour

would probably never say that.”

“I’m very proud of you all,” added Professor Mansour, “for engaging and supporting the UKCGE’s first conference for equity, diversity and inclusion. It means a lot. My advice is to close the gap – please take what you’ve learnt to your institutions. Also, student voices matter and we had fantastic contributions from our PGR panel yesterday. I genuinely enjoyed every minute of it.”

UKCGE Commitment

As a follow-up to the conference, we held an online discussion for participants and interested parties on March 8th 2024. This provided a summary of events for those who were unable to attend and there were also updates on the presentations and initiatives presented at the conference in Sheffield.

Additionally, we have made a commitment to EDI in our own operations – by developing a UKCGE policy along with a statement to accompany our

events. We have also begun – in cases where our events participants have given their permission – to collect and analyse the relevant data so that we can see where gaps need addressing. The positive responses to these events have shown that there is an appetite for tackling these issues within the postgraduate sector, and we plan to develop more opportunities to address inequalities in the future.

For our EDI policy please visit ukcge.ac.uk/principles-and-policies.



Left: Professor Jason Arday giving his keynote in Sheffield. Photo © Annette Rubery.



Dr James Bruce, Honorary Treasurer UKCGE

Financial Statement 2022-23

Dear colleagues,

The UKCGE financial year runs from August to July, so this statement reports on the financial year ending in July 2023.

As with many small charities and organisations, the Council was significantly impacted by the pandemic. For us, it meant that we could no longer rely on income from event registration fees. Between 2019 and 2020, our events income fell from £244,832 (65% of our income) to £78,895 (40% of our income). We coped with this challenge by relying

on our charitable reserves, by cutting expenditure where we could (including on staff development), and by allowing one of our staff roles to remain vacant for 18 months. We also put an increased emphasis on our ability to generate income by conducting research and undertaking consultancy work for our members and other sector bodies. Following these measures, I am pleased to report that for the year ending July 2023, the Council created a surplus of £44,596. This means that our charitable reserves now stand at

£290,779, which is in line with our reserves policy. This puts us in a strong position to develop the Council's activities over the next four years. In that time, we will be recruiting an additional "Policy and Research" staff member, we will continue to upgrade our web presence, we will develop our research and consultancy work, and we will invest in additional training and development of our staff. Thank you for your continued support.

James Bruce

Income

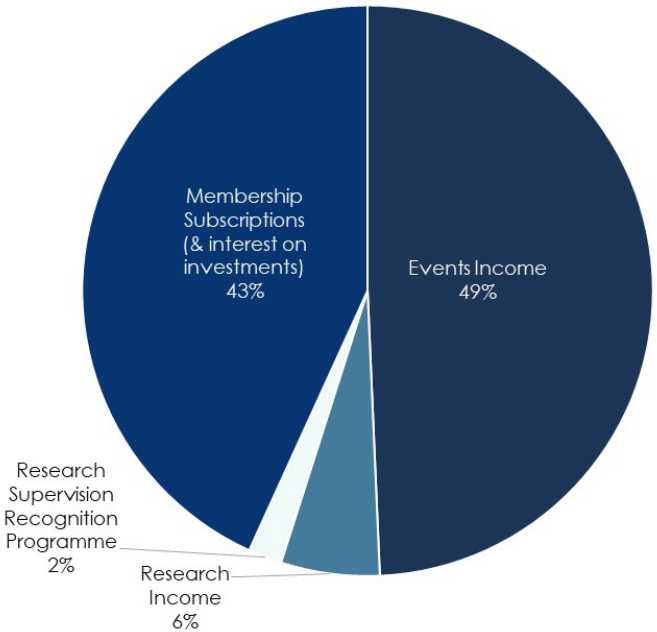
Membership Subscriptions	£121,352
Event income	£140,064
Other income	£22,599
Income total	£284,015

Expenditure

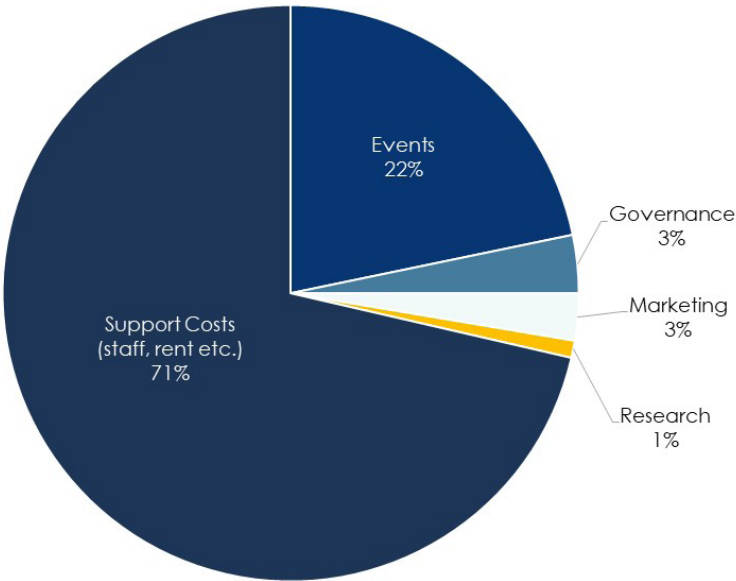
Support costs (staff, rent etc.)	£170,950
Event costs	£52,063
Other costs	£16,406
Expenditure total	£239,419

Total Surplus / (Deficit)	£44,596
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income



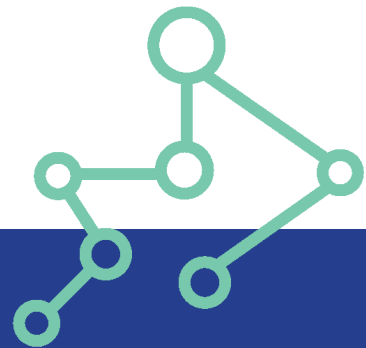
expenditure





Thank You

Please get in touch if you have ideas for events or resources that would assist your work in the future.



OUR DETAILS

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